

secrets to the method of our madness. The goal is the same: get the best values and pay as little as possible. Then, of course, there is the ultimate goal of getting something free. If companies haven't learned that simple lesson by now, then they could simply deduce it from the marketing mistakes of others.

Several years ago, the Sears Corporation distributed a "\$5 off any purchase" coupon in the moving booklets available at post offices throughout the United States. When I heard about this amazing coupon, I immediately wondered, *What were they thinking?*, the "they" being the marketers behind such a concept. I knew what would happen as soon as the coupon community got wind of the offer, and I was right.

The intention of the coupon was one thing, the implementation of it yet another. While intended for use by the person picking up the moving booklet (*that is someone who was actually moving*) surely the Sears Corporation could have anticipated that there would be others picking up the moving booklets and using the coupons as well. What they hadn't taken into account was the group of people who would pick up more than one booklet, people like Grace J. of Colorado, who visited all of the post offices within a fifty-mile radius, picking up a dozen booklets in every town, clipping out the coupon, then driving to the nearby malls to search for a Sears store and hitting every checkout with coupon in hand. By the time the coupon expired, Grace estimates she got over three thousand dollars worth of underpants, socks, and clearance-priced merchandise totally free.

Grace was not alone. Even I, limited to one post office and one Sears store, managed to make enough visits before the coupon expired to net at